The Portrait

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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by Friendlylycanthrope

Summary

Adora, Catra, and Glimmer can put it off no longer: they sit for their royal portrait now that they are married Queens of Brightmoon. It gives them time to think about how far they have each come.

The royal throne room was under a bit of a conversion. Not just to add a second and even third throne at Glimmer's sides. But now that it had been a few months since the big royal wedding, they really couldn't put off the royal portrait any longer. Tarps were put down to protect the polished stone floors. A huge, elegantly clear canvas was waiting for strokes. Filters were put on the windows to preserve just the right lighting, and the air smelled of oil paints.

Adora was the first one there. She was good at keeping schedules. She wore her finest clothes for the occasion, even wore her hair down so she could really look her best. She was trying out different types of heroic poses with her sword when Catra came in and smirked, leaning on the door frame.

"You know you'll have to hold that position for a few hours, right?" She smiled. Adora blushed and put the sword down.

Catra came over and kissed her wife. She would never get tired of that. Being *wives*. Being queens would take even longer to adjust to. But after years of hardships and rock bottoms and struggle, here she was. In a throne room. With her lifelong love, Adora, in her arms and against her lips.

"Am I interrupting?" The third of their trio appeared, walking with a cool confidence that tried to reflect her position. She came over and fixed Adora's hair a bit, having to reach up to the tallest among them from the shortest. Catra chuckled at their height difference.

“Catra, tell me you at least put a brush through that mane?” Glimmer asked, turning her attention to the other, making sure all of them looked their best. Catra smirked.

“Wouldn’t you like to know?” She teased.

Adora raised an eyebrow. “Hey, I let my hair down for this. You know how rare that is. Can’t you brush yours?” She smirked.

“Hey, do you want me to look my best, or do you want me to look my most *me?* ” Catra defended coolly, staying true to her more authentic self.

The painter came in with Angella then, who had to come see the momentous occasion. The artist was a highly skilled elf from one of the cities in Brightmoon, hand picked for her realism despite her young age. She bowed deeply.

“Your Majesties! Thank you again for this honor of memorializing your reign. I am of course your artist, Lysa.”

“You don’t have to bow, Lysa.” Glimmer waved nervously. It still felt odd to have people kneel or bow before them, she felt like a kid at heart being treated like some holy figure.

Lysa stood up “Of course, your majesty!” She began to squeeze out paints to her palette. Angella came over and looked them each over.

“Well done, you three. You look regal. Catra, would you like a hair tie?”

“How come she gets to have a hair tie?” Adora asked quietly. Just to make Adora squirm more, Catra accepted it and put her messy hair in a high ponytail. It looked robust, and yet at the same time carefully refined, like a businesswoman.

“This is a big day for you three.” Angella said with pride. “The portrait is an essential part of how we are remembered, even generations later.”

“Really?” Adora said nervously. She was fine with a fancy painting, but being remembered forever? That sounded like more pressure than she was expecting.

Glimmer nodded. “The Royal portrait of my dad is one of the best preserved depictions we have of him.” She said fondly. Angella nodded with a somber smile. Then began to arrange them in the best positions.

“There we are, now Glimmer you sit here. Don’t forget your staff. Perhaps more of an angle – no, the other way. That’s it. Then Catra, at this shoulder. Lovely. Adora, right here at this shoulder.”

She had Glimmer sit in an opulent hand crafted chair. Catra was at Glimmer's right, with a hand on her shoulder in support. Adora did the same at her left, while her free hand held the sword pointing down to the floor. With a few little adjustments of how their shoulders faced, the direction of the neck, the bend of the knee, Angella was certain that they were all set.

"Perfect." She smiled, and gave a thumbs up to Lysa.

"So we just stay exactly like this, for hours?" Catra asked, full of a bit of dread. She wasn't one for sitting still. She liked action, but also naps. Naps where she could roll and stretch if needed.

"Please, no movement." Lysa kindly reminded them, which had Catra shut her mouth for the rest of the session though she was thinking nothing but grumbling.

The first ten minutes, they all thought this was fine, they could keep this up as long as they needed to.

After that, the soreness crept in. Catra's was tired of being on her feet, Adora's arm was getting tired of holding the heavy sword so still in place, and Glimmer's butt was getting numb from the insanely fancy chair. Angella sat and admired the work of the artist as the vision slowly came to life, and yet none of them could see it until it was complete, for it was facing away from them.

Adora stared straight ahead, just as Angella had instructed her, softly looking into the middle distance near the artist. She was really starting to regret offering to bring the sword and holding it at this angle. If the tip were at least touching the floor, she could balance. But holding the hilt up near her ribs meant more strength. Not that strength was ever a problem for Adora. She adjusted her grip slightly – there was no talking, but no rules about subtle fidgeting – and let her thoughts wander. She wondered how much of their story, their personality could be captured in simple brushstrokes. Would they know she used to fear this sword, even as she carried it? Would they see the weight in her shoulders as strength, or something she once had to unlearn?

It was strange to be immortalized like this. She never thought she would share a throne over any of the Princess kingdoms. If young Horde Adora could see her now, she would balk. So much had changed. Ever since that one fateful day where she made Force Captain, leading to her discovering the sword, and making decisions that would decide the fate of Ethera, she wondered if she would change any of it.

She smiled and subtly looked over to Catra, then back ahead. Of course, some things were still the same. It was hard to picture the rest of her life without both her lifelong affection, as well as a new world of softness and forgiveness that came with Glimmer. The two of them each had equal share in her heart. Not as She-Ra, but as Adora.

Brightmoon came with so much grace for her that she wasn't expecting. She was forgiven for simple mistakes. She was allowed to show her emotions. She was able to figure out who she was without fear of ending on the "wrong" answer. And she *did* end up

finding herself. And regardless of mistakes of the past, she was right where she wanted to be now. She knew that tough things were worth fighting for, and it wouldn't be easy. But letting others help with that fight made it easier.

Adora smiled faintly. Not the fake smile for a photo like she was instructed, but one where her heart felt warm. There were so many small instances, every day, for years now, where she realized how free she was. It would never get old. There was a time when Adora thought that love was not meant for her – for others perhaps, but she had always believed she was built for battle. But now? Every stolen moment curled in bed, every shared laugh at midnight… it was hers too.

A soft sigh broke the silence—barely more than a breath. It came from Glimmer. Adora didn't move, but she caught the familiar rhythm of restlessness beside her.

Glimmer shifted slightly in the oversized throne chair, trying to ease the pressure on one leg. The fabric of her dress rustled as she did. She wasn't supposed to move, but what was she supposed to do? Pretend her entire leg wasn't going numb? She started by trying to distract herself in some way, any small thing. She began counting the number of brush strokes that Lysa made against the canvas. But eventually it became hard to count as the swishing on the other side of the canvas became more indistinct to blend colors together.

The portrait would likely outlive all of them, perfectly preserving their youth in the castle halls for generations to come. Glimmer hoped that she had made the right choice in artist, and that it looked honest rather than just flattering. She could remember being small and finding the portrait of her mother and father just

after their own wedding, looking regal and graceful, powerful yet tender.

All her life, she had always been chasing something. She always knew that one day she would come to fill this role. She wanted to be as wise and respected as her parents were. They were more than just her predecessors, leaving big shoes to fill: they were her heroes. Even if she had a lot of trouble telling them.

She had believed that fighting in the war, being a general making tough calls, being in combat, would make her more tough and wise. In reality, it was the opposite of war that helped her mature: patient, understanding love to ground her.

Adora came into her life with all the subtlety of a Fireball spell, and sometimes that was how it felt: powerful, filling the room with her presence, warming her cheeks, burning with a passion. And Glimmer had been drawn to Adora like a moth to that flame, helping temper it to the steady glow of a candle, and in return finding light.

Then there was Catra. At first a nuisance, then a competitor for Adora's attention. She wasn't too proud to admit that when Adora was making plans with Catra in secret about the war, she felt a pang of jealousy. But the thorn in her side had plenty of her own problems, and had done more to fight for her life than perhaps Glimmer ever would. Catra had proven with her sharp claws and sharper words that she deserved a spot on this planet, that her cunning could save the world, and that even someone cold on the outside had a passion deep within.

Glimmer smiled. How lucky she was, she thought to herself, to have both her partners join her in one aspect of immortality, their image being preserved and revered. She wouldn't be the queen she is now without them.

Glimmer shifted again—no doubt going slowly numb in that ridiculously overstuffed chair. Catra envied her. At least Glimmer got to *sit* .

Catra didn't know how she always got talked into these things. Standing still in a suit that was too tight, beside her wives in full royal regalia, while some art kid tried to capture her "essence." Whatever that meant. She would rather be sparring. Or napping. Or literally *anywhere* else.

It wasn't that she didn't see the importance of the portrait, she really did see how it was a symbol of their reign. These images would probably end up on post cards, and coronation memorabilia, and stamps for Brightmoon heritage.

The problem was more about her significance in it. Of course, she had been coronated as a Queen of Brightmoon along with her two brides. But it was oddly jarring to hear people say "Long live the Queen!" when she passed through towns. The other two, Glimmer and Adora, just made sense. They were princesses, born to a power greater than themselves. Catra had helped win the war, yes. But she also escalated a lot of it for the first half of her involvement. Would she go down in history as the General who switched sides, betraying loyalty to the horde? Or would they erase those less favorable parts of her life, and remember her simply as a general who defeated Hordak? She wasn't sure which was worse: the truth, or the lie.

Then again, she had to remind herself that she had every right to be here, princess or not. She had done the hard work herself of carving away her worst parts to reveal the true art beneath. She had spent the time alone trying to figure out who she was and what she wanted. She had even patiently let affection build within her when in the past, she would have lashed out at something so foreign building in her.

And now here she was: a part of history. There was a time when she was the smallest cadet in the nursery, hiding in the corner. And now she stood tall, proud of who she had become. And she wouldn’t be here today if not for the reassurance of two princesses that she shared a bed with.

Her ears flicked as a soft brushstroke echoed through the studio, breaking the long silence. For a moment, Catra wondered how much of their story Lysa could see just from their posture alone – how much they'd all changed.

Maybe this wasn’t just a portrait. Maybe it was a promise.

She didn’t move. But she let herself relax – just a little.

They had all earned their place. In the castle, in history, and in each other’s arms.

The hours stretched on before them, each queen considering how far they had come. Once a hotheaded rebel, a devoted soldier, and a lovesick ball of anger, they had now all come to a place of peace and understanding. They could stand proudly together as a bright young queen, a protector of balance, and a wise wild card.

The afternoon came, the stiffness was stubbornly held, and they waited as patiently as they could Until at long last, Lysa smiled in satisfaction and put down her brush.

Three collective sighs followed, the kind that were equal parts relief and release. Glimmer rubbed her legs, Adora shook out her sore arm, and Catra stretched with a catlike groan that echoed against the vaulted ceiling. Relief flooded through them as they moved again. They each smiled tiredly at each other.

“Didn’t think you could sit still for that long, Catra.” Glimmer teased lovingly. Catra smirked and flipped her hair.

“What can I say, I wanted to last longer than you two with all your fidgeting.”

“I wasn’t fidgeting that much, was I?” Adora chuckled, still rolling her shoulders.

Angella cleared her throat, a polite reminder that all their efforts had been worth a big payoff. She waved for them to come see the canvas, and they gathered around to see the work.

It was breathtaking.

The colors were soft, yet powerful. Glimmer sat with her staff in hand, not just as a ruler, but as someone kind and grounded. Adora stood tall, her sword gleaming with a light that seemed to come from the canvas itself, her strength tempered with warmth. And Catra—Catra was the surprise. Her expression wasn't fierce or guarded, but quietly defiant. Regal. Whole. She looked like someone who had *earned* her place, not someone who had wandered into it.

Together, they looked balanced. Unified. The very image of love and leadership, captured forever in oil and time.

Glimmer smiled through misty eyes, and took her wives' hands.

"We really did this." She nodded, feeling the weight of the crown on her head, not for the first time and certainly not for the last. Angella rested a hand on her shoulder, full of pride.

They stood there a while longer, three queens and their legacy, watching their story painted in permanence.

And for once, none of them felt the need to rush.

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